

THE SOFRITO MASTERCLASS

La base de todo

The green and red foundation of Puerto Rican cooking — what it is, how to build it, and the five dishes it transforms.

Authentic recipes · Bilingual · From the Ortiz kitchen
Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com



Sofrito Is the Foundation

Almost every savory boricua dish begins with the same two spoonfuls. Sofrito (and its lighter, greener cousin recaito) is the aromatic base — garlic, peppers, onion, cilantro — pureed and cooked down. It is not a condiment; it is the beginning of everything. Once you master it, the whole table opens up.

The Master Sofrito

Homemade Sofrito — Puerto Rican Flavor Base Recipe

Sofrito · The flavor base of every Puerto Rican dish — recaio, garlic, peppers, and herbs. Make a batch in 20 minutes.

Ingredients

- 1 bunch recaio (cilantro), about 15 leaves
- 1 large green bell pepper, seeded and chopped
- 1 medium onion, quartered
- 8 cloves garlic, peeled
- 1/2 cup cilantro (fresh coriander), with stems
- 2 tablespoons olive oil
- 1 teaspoon salt

Steps

1. Wash all herbs and vegetables thoroughly.
2. Add recaio, bell pepper, onion, garlic, and cilantro to a food processor.
3. Pulse until finely chopped but not pureed — you want texture.
4. Add olive oil and salt. Pulse 3-4 more times to combine.
5. Transfer to ice cube trays or jars. Freeze in portions for up to 3 months.

Recaito — The Green Base

Recaito

Recaito · The no-tomato green base that gives rice and stews their signature flavor.

Ingredients

- 1 bunch cilantro
- 1 bunch culantro (or extra cilantro)
- 1 green pepper (cubanelle)
- 2 ají dulce or 1/2 habanero (seeded, optional heat)
- 1 large onion
- 6 garlic cloves
- 1/2 tsp salt

Steps

1. Roughly chop all ingredients.
2. Puree in a food processor or blender until a thick, slightly chunky paste forms.
3. Refrigerate up to a week or freeze in 2-tbsp cubes for up to 3 months.

Dish One: Arroz con Pollo

Arroz con Pollo — Authentic Puerto Rican Chicken and Rice Recipe

Arroz Con Pollo · One pot, chicken and rice, deeply flavored with sofrito and sazón. Puerto Rican comfort food at its best.

Ingredients

- 2 lbs chicken pieces
- 2 cups rice
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 cup tomato sauce
- 2.5 cups chicken broth
- 1/2 cup olives
- 1/2 cup peas
- 2 tablespoons oil
- Salt and pepper to taste

Steps

1. Season chicken pieces with salt and pepper. Brown in oil over medium-high heat, about 4 minutes per side. Remove and set aside.
2. In the same pot, sauté the sofrito for 2 minutes. Add sazón and tomato sauce, stir to combine.
3. Add rice and stir to coat in the sofrito mixture.
4. Pour in chicken broth, add chicken pieces back in along with olives. Bring to a boil.
5. Cover, reduce heat to low, and cook for 25 minutes. Add peas during the last 5 minutes. Fluff and serve.

Dish Two: Habichuelas Guisadas

Habichuelas Guisadas — Authentic Puerto Rican Stewed Beans Recipe

Habichuelas · The everyday Puerto Rican side dish — thick, savory bean stew with calabaza that accompanies rice on virtually every plate.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz) pink beans
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons tomato paste
- 1/2 cup pumpkin (calabaza) cubed
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon cumin
- 1 cup water
- 2 tablespoons oil
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a medium pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 3 minutes until fragrant and softened.
2. Add tomato paste and cook for 1 minute, stirring constantly to caramelize it slightly.
3. Toss in the cubed pumpkin, sazón, and cumin. Stir to coat the pumpkin in the flavor base.
4. Add the beans (with their liquid) and water. Stir well and bring to a boil.
5. Reduce heat and simmer for 20 minutes until the pumpkin is fork-tender and the broth has thickened.
6. Mash some of the pumpkin pieces against the side of the pot to thicken the stew. Taste and adjust salt before serving.

Dish Three: Arroz con Gandules

Arroz con Gandules — Authentic Puerto Rican Rice and Pigeon Peas Recipe

Arroz Con Gandules · Puerto Rico's national dish — rice, pigeon peas, and sofrito. The one-pot meal every boricua makes for holidays.

Ingredients

- 2 cups long-grain rice
- 1 can (15 oz) gandules (pigeon peas), drained
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons vegetable oil
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon ground cumin
- 2.5 cups chicken broth
- 1/2 cup manzanilla olives with pimiento
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a large caldero or heavy pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 2 minutes until fragrant.
2. Add drained gandules and cook for 3 minutes, stirring occasionally.
3. Stir in sazón and cumin. Cook for 1 minute to bloom the spices.
4. Add rice and stir to coat every grain in the sofrito mixture.
5. Pour in chicken broth, add olives, and bring to a boil. Stir once, then reduce heat to low.
6. Cover tightly and cook for 25 minutes without lifting the lid. Fluff with a fork before serving.

Dish Four: Mofongo

Mofongo — Authentic Puerto Rican Mashed Plantains Recipe

Mofongo · Fried green plantains mashed with garlic, chicharron, and olive oil. Puerto Rico's most iconic dish.

Ingredients

- 4 green plantains
- 6 cloves garlic, minced
- 1/2 cup chicharron (pork cracklings), crushed
- 3 tablespoons olive oil
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 1/2 cup warm chicken broth

Steps

1. Peel plantains by cutting off both ends, scoring the skin lengthwise, and prying it off.
2. Cut into 1-inch rounds. Fry at 350°F until golden, about 3-4 minutes per side.
3. Drain and transfer to a mortar (pilon) or large bowl while hot.
4. Add garlic, chicharron, olive oil, and salt. Mash vigorously.
5. Add warm broth gradually, mashing until dense but holds together.
6. Shape into a dome and serve immediately.

Dish Five: Sofrito Mojo for Anything

Sofrito-Garlic Mojo

Mojo de sofrito y ajo · A spoonful of sofrito makes a sauce that turns chicken, rice, and eggs into dinner.

Ingredients

- 2 tbsp sofrito
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tbsp lime or sour orange juice
- 1/2 tsp adobo

Steps

1. Warm the olive oil and garlic over low heat until fragrant, about 1 minute — do not brown.
2. Stir in the sofrito and adobo, cook 2 minutes more.
3. Finish with the lime juice off the heat. Spoon over rice, roasted chicken, or fried eggs.

Batch, Store, Freeze

Make sofrito in double batches. Freeze in ice-cube trays at 2 tablespoons each, pop into a bag, and pull a cube whenever a recipe calls for it. Properly frozen sofrito holds its flavor for about 3 months — long enough to outlast any sofrito emergency.